off side. While there was always the risk of a top edge, I was prepared to accept it to surprise Warne. After all, he was Australia's most potent weapon and I had to have a strategy against him.

Having worked on the theory, I now needed to practise against the kind of deliveries Warne would use when under pressure. I started training in late January, with still a month to go before the series, and asked for the best spinners available in Mumbai to bowl at me from round the wicket into the rough outside leg stump. I was certain that's what Warne would do if I succeeded in attacking him when he bowled from over the wicket. All that practice in Mumbai against Sairaj Bahutule and Nilesh Kulkarni, both of whom played for India against Australia in 2001, and subsequently in Chennai against Laxman Sivaramakrishnan, now a respected television commentator who played for India in the mid-1980s, proved immensely useful, and by the time the Australians arrived in India in February 1998 I felt ready to face Warne.

## An early skirmish

The first game the Australians played was against Mumbai on 24 February. I was captaining Mumbai and knew it was crucial to establish a psychological advantage over the visitors at the start of the tour. The most important thing was to attack Warne. I had instructed all our batsmen to take Warne on whenever he came on to bowl. I did not care if we lost wickets, but there was no way we would allow Warne to settle into his groove and dictate terms.

When it was our turn to bat, Amit Pagnis, opening the batting for Mumbai, did exactly what we had planned. Though we lost an early wicket in Sulakshan Kulkarni, Pagnis and I attacked Warne from the start. While Pagnis hit Warne for four boundaries in two overs, I hit him for a six in his very first over and continued to attack him right through the innings. His sixteen overs cost him 111 runs and that was far more important than my own double hundred off 192 balls – though I was particularly pleased with my effort because I had made a conscious attempt to dominate the bowling and it was my first double in first-class cricket. Having conceded a lead of more than 100 in the first innings, the Australians collapsed to 135 all out in their second innings, with Nilesh Kulkarni, who had first played for India in 1996, running through half